

Job lifecycle, deadlines & notifications

A proposal for how jobs stay open, when producers decide, what happens at cancel/expire, and how musicians get notified — for review tonight.

Audience: Retrack This team · **Goal:** Align on timing + cancel CX + Follow/notifications before we build the next slice

1. The problem we're solving

Musicians were getting confused or upset when jobs closed early — typically because a producer picked a winner before the deadline, which used to capture payment, unlock stems, and stop new submissions immediately.

We want a model where: submissions stay fair until a clear cutoff; producers still get time to listen and confirm; payment and WAV unlocks happen at a predictable moment; and cancellations / expiry feel clear for everyone — not like work disappeared into limbo.

2. Already shipped (live)

- Jobs stay **open for submissions until the deadline**, even if a producer picks early.
- Early picks are **provisional (“Selected”)** — producer can switch until time is up.
- **Payment + WAV downloads unlock at deadline** (lazy finalize on job list fetch).
- Producer sees a wait note explaining why they can't download yet.
- Existing open jobs already use this behavior; already-awarded jobs unchanged.

Still in place today

If the deadline passes with **no** selection, there is still a ~72 hour grace window, then auto-cancel + refund. Tonight's proposal replaces that grace with a clearer 12-hour producer-review window *before* the hard deadline.

3. Proposed timing model

DECIDED — 12 hours always carved out of the posted window

Whatever length the producer chooses, the **last 12 hours belong to the producer** for verify/confirm. Musicians get the rest.

- **7-day job** → musicians ~6.5 days to submit, producer last 12 hours
- **1-day job** → musicians 12 hours, producer 12 hours
- Same rule for any other length (minimum job length must stay ≥ 12 hours so both sides get a window).

Treat the producer's posted deadline as the **hard end** of the job (award / charge / or cancel). Submissions close at **T – 12 hours**.

Example windows

Producer picks	Musician submit window	Producer review	Hard end (T)
7 days	6 days 12 hours	Final 12 hours	Day 7 — award or cancel
3 days	2 days 12 hours	Final 12 hours	Day 3 — award or cancel
1 day	12 hours	Final 12 hours	24 hours — award or cancel

Phases

Phase	When	Who can act	What happens
Open	Start → T–12h	Musicians submit / replace; producer can provisional-select anytime	Marketplace shows days left; under 24h to submit-close, show hours
Producer review	T–12h → T	No new submissions; producer confirms or switches pick	Pill: hours left to confirm; job off the open board for new takes
Deadline (T)	Exact end	System	If selected → auto-award (pay + unlock WAVs). If nobody selected → auto-cancel + refund

This replaces today's fuzzy post-deadline grace. The 12 hours **is** the buffer — clearer for musicians and producers. Keeps Stripe's ~7-day card hold aligned with job end.

Countdown display

- ≥ 24 hours until the relevant cutoff: “3 days left”, “1 day left”, etc.
- Under 24 hours: switch to hours — “23 hours left” → “1 hour left”.
- Optional near the end: “Closing soon” under ~30 minutes.
- In the last day, prefer two labels: “Submissions close in ...” then “Decision due in ...” once review starts.

Product copy implication

The post-job control shouldn't imply musicians get the full number of days. Something like “Job length” with helper text: *Last 12 hours are reserved for your decision; submissions close before then*. On the musician side, the pill should track **submission close** (T–12h), not the hard end — so a 1-day job correctly shows ~12 hours to submit, not 24.

4. Auto-award vs auto-cancel at T

Situation at deadline	System action	Producer	Musician
Someone is selected (expected)	Finalize award: capture escrow, pay musician, unlock masters, status → AWARDED	Gets stems; charged	Gets paid + “you won” email
Nobody selected (forgot / didn't like takes)	Auto-cancel: release hold, status → CANCELLED, reason expired_no_winner	Full refund; sees Cancelled on dashboard	Submitters get cancel email; no pay
Producer hits Cancel anytime before finalize	Same cancel path; reason producer	Full refund	Submitters (+ followers, if we add Follow) emailed

5. Cancelled jobs, submissions & stems — no “no man’s land”

Don't invent a limbo status. **CANCELLED** is the right terminal state, optionally with a **cancelReason** (*producer / expired_no_winner*).

Asset	Recommendation	Why
Marketplace listing	Hide immediately	Stops new interest; avoids zombie gigs
Producer dashboard	Keep row as Cancelled (title, instrument, reason)	Accountability + support context
Musician My submissions	Keep as Job cancelled; they can still open their take	Their work shouldn't vanish
WAV / stems for producer	Never unlock on cancel	They didn't pay — downloads only after award
File storage	Keep ~90 days, then delete blobs; keep DB rows (or soft-delete URLs)	Support / disputes without forever orphan files

Good CX is short emails that say *why* — “Deadline ended with no selection — hold released” vs “Producer cancelled the job” — not silence and missing jobs.

6. Who gets emailed on cancel

Audience	Email?	Notes
Everyone who submitted	Yes	Already partly in place
Everyone who followed (if built)	Yes	Same cancel path as submitters
All musicians who play that instrument	No	Too spammy for people who never engaged

7. Follow a job

Let musicians **Follow** a job to watch it without submitting. Anyone who submits can be **auto-followed** so they don't miss outcome emails.

Suggested notification matrix

Event	In-app	Email	Notes
Your take selected (provisional)	Yes	Optional soft note	Avoid "you're paid" until finalize
You won / paid (final)	Yes	Yes	High signal
Job cancelled / expired	Yes	Yes	High signal
Price increased	Yes	Yes (or in-app if small)	Encourages competing
Entering producer-review (12h)	Yes	Optional	"Submissions closed — decision window"
New submissions	Batched	Rare / digest / off by default	Don't ping every take
Deadline extended	Yes	Yes	If we ever allow extensions

Spam risk

Pinging on every new take burns trust fast. Prefer batched in-app updates ("3 new submissions") or a daily digest. Keep award / cancel / price-up as the sharp emails.

8. In-app notification bell

- Unread count on the hamburger control in the site header.
- Drawer / panel: recent job + account events, mark read, deep-link to the job.
- Start simple: **Notification** rows in the DB + refresh on navigate (no websockets day one).
- Reuse existing email-pref pattern (e.g. notifyFollowUpdates) so people can tune noise.

9. Recommended build order

Slice	Scope	Why first / later
1. Timing + hours	Hours when < 1 day; 12h carved-out producer review; auto-award / auto-cancel at T; drop post-deadline 72h grace; copy updates	Fixes fairness + clarity; builds on what we just shipped
2. Cancel polish	cancelReason; clearer emails; 90-day retention policy documented in product + support	Small but makes expiry feel intentional
3. Follow + bell	Follow button; notification table; hamburger badge; matrix above	Bigger surface — do once timing feels right

10. Decisions for tonight

Locked from pre-meeting feedback, plus remaining open items:

- **D1.** Carve 12 producer hours *out of* the posted deadline (not added on top) — including 1-day jobs = 12h musician / 12h producer.
- **D2.** Drop the post-deadline 72h grace in favor of auto-cancel at T if no selection?
- **D3.** Keep CANCELLED as the only terminal cancel state (no limbo), with cancelReason?
- **D4.** ~90-day file retention after cancel, then delete storage blobs?
- **D5.** Cancel emails only to submitters + followers (never whole instrument list)?
- **D6.** Soft “selected pending deadline” email, or wait until final award to email the musician?
- **D7.** Ship Follow + bell as slice 3 after timing, or pull forward?
- **D8.** Rename post-job “days” label / helper so producers understand last 12h are for their decision?

Notes from the meeting

Prepared for Retrack This team review · Job lifecycle & notifications · Sep 16, 2026 · D1 locked